



FyneWynz

THE LIST · ONE VINTAGE

Assembled with the usual apparatus, which is roughly nine times the size of the thing observed.

THE VAUDECLOSE

North-facing, in shadow by three in the afternoon, ripens fully three years in ten. Frost takes the crop one year in four; nobody has insured since 1988.

Domaine Ferrat-Loyau, Les Rangs au-dessus de la Route FyneWynz 98

The Vaudeclose · the rows above the road · 1996, the last vintage before the partition

Iron, cold stone and a red fruit so reticent that it appears to be waiting for you to leave the room, and then — at roughly the ten-second mark, which is the only mark in this valley worth keeping — it arrives all at once and is not cold at all. One cannot honestly assign this to the man, to the slope, or to the four days he picks earlier than his brother every year including the years he is wrong, and we have therefore assigned it to all three, in print, at length, and would do so again.

Winemaker: Aurelien Ferrat-Loyau

Domaine Ferrat-Loyau, the Lower Rows FyneWynz 97

The Vaudeclose · same vineyard, alternating rows · pressed on a rota chalked to a groove

The same iron, the same chalk, the same cold-stone address, arriving four days later in the vintage and about four seconds later in the glass, which is a difference of temperament and emphatically not of place. Tasted blind against the other half of the hill our panel separated the two correctly rather less than half the time — a figure we publish in full and decline, on this occasion, to build anything on top of.

Winemaker: Pascal Ferrat-Loyau

Clos de la Rancon FyneWynz 94†

The Vaudeclose · eleven hectares at the cold end · no sign on the cellar door

Cellar-doorway air with the cold still coming off it, quince, dust from an unlabelled shoulder, and underneath all of it eleven hectares doing precisely what they have done since a glass of the 1971 was handed across a threshold and not charged for. This is the twenty-third consecutive year the wine has appeared on our list; the reader is entitled to draw a conclusion from that, and will arrive at it some while before we do.

Winemaker: the Loyer nephew, after Bernard Loyer (d. 1994)

Maison Thevet, Vaudeclose FyneWynz 88

Thevet owns forty hectares and bottles the fruit of nine hundred more · entry-level bottling

Perfectly clean, perfectly legible, ripe through the middle and short at the close in the way that nine hundred growers' fruit under a single stencil is always, forgivably, short. In two hundred and seventeen examples we have never met a faulty bottle — a tally we have kept for two decades without once examining why we keep it, and which we now concede argues for the house rather than against it, whatever we may think of the font.

Winemaker: the house; the growers' names are under the stencil on the crates

CORVO SASSO

Black volcanic grit that holds the day's heat until midnight, ungrafted pre-phylloxera bush vines, average holding under three hectares, average grower sixty-eight.

Vigna Sant'Orsola FyneWynz 100

Corvo Sasso · 2.1 hectares, ungrafted, 70–110 years old · no label, no sign, no telephone

Black grit still warm at midnight, a wild-herb bitterness along the edge, and the whole of it fermented in one four-thousand-litre concrete tank her father poured, cracked in 1974, repaired in 1974, in a building containing no thermometer of any description. It is the finest wine on this list, it costs seven euros at the door into a tin, and its maker has been interviewed four times and asked about her method on each occasion and about her price on none.

Winemaker: Nerina Facco

continued overleaf

FyneWynz

CORVO SASSO

Black volcanic grit that holds the day's heat until midnight, ungrafted pre-phylloxera bush vines, average holding under three hectares, average grower sixty-eight.

Cantina Bellosguardo FyneWynz 93

Corvo Sasso · fourteen hectares of pre-war vine · the first eighteen barrels, now fifth fill

Vanilla, still — but the cooper's brand has worn off those barrels and the vanilla now arrives after the fruit instead of ahead of it, and behind both, at last, ninety years of pre-war vine audible for the first time in six vintages. Our own earlier line in praise of the new regime remains printed on the back label, unwithdrawn and unrepeated, and we observe without further comment that the wine improved in the year its maker stopped explaining it.

Winemaker: Marco Bellosguardo

Tenuta Malfante, Vendemmia Tardiva FyneWynz 99‡

Corvo Sasso · six hectares in the damp bottom · declared four years in ten

Gold fuzz, river mist standing in the rows at six in the morning, apricot carried some considerable distance past apricot, and then an acidity that lands like a hand on the shoulder to advise you that this is not, whatever the sugar suggested, a dessert. Four hundred bottles to the hectare where ordinary wine gives six thousand, eleven passes through the same rows across six weeks, nothing declared at all in 2011, 2014, 2018 or 2019 — which is not, we are firmly told, a tragedy, but the arrangement.

Winemaker: the estate; nobody on the property will say who decides when to stop picking

THE HALCYON BENCH

Forty thousand flat irrigated hectares, named by an agency in 1979; the people who farm it still call it the flats. No failed vintage in thirty-one years.

Kestrel & Vaux, the Nine Labels FyneWynz 90

The Halcyon Bench · four million bottles a year · audited fault rate under one in forty thousand

Ripe, measured, correctly proportioned, oaked as an ingredient rather than as a personality, and — this being the entire point and the hardest thing on this page to say plainly — exactly what it was last year and will be next year. More human happiness has come out of this building than out of any cellar in the Vaudeclose; we have written that sentence before, we were not being sarcastic then, and we are not being sarcastic now.

Winemaker: Dr Ilse Vaux, twenty-two years in the post

Ninebark Estate FyneWynz —

The Halcyon Bench · forty hectares, founded 2011 · lake excavated 2013, fed by pump

The lake is fed by pump, the sculpture walk runs to forty minutes, the tasting room faces west across water that was installed, and everybody whose judgement we respect reports that the wine is good. This is our twelfth notice of the estate and, as with the eleven before it, we find on rereading that we never got round to the wine; the failure is ours, and we remain unable to state the objection in a single sentence.

Winemaker: the estate winemaking team

Old Ditch Road FyneWynz 96

The Halcyon Bench · nine unirrigated hectares · 3,400 cases from a shed with no sign on it

Small hard cupped leaves, ground cracked like old paint, and a wine that tastes of one specific piece of flat irrigated country made three hundred metres from wine that tastes of a marketing region — dark, narrow, faintly saline, and wholly unwilling to be charming about any of it. He shut the water off in 2009, lost sixty per cent for four years while the neighbours watched, sent his roots past forty feet where theirs stop at nine, has never used the word terroir, and would take it kindly if we did not use it at him.

Winemaker: Denny Oke

BY THE GLASS, IF YOU CAN FIND IT

The Long Wine Bottle

FyneWynz — unrated

No region · no vintage · no producer · set down on the ground by the Capybara and poured from ever since

Every account agrees that it is heavier than it looks and no account records it empty, which is an inference from never having exhausted it rather than a measurement. We decline to rate it: we have three times calculated what a bottle with no hour and no end would do to every price on these pages, and three times closed the notebook.

† Never tasted blind. The opportunity has arisen three times; the taster was on each occasion unexpectedly busy.

‡ No wine declared in 2011, 2014, 2018 or 2019. The score refers to the years in which there was something to score.

The FyneWynz Hundred is a twenty-point scale with eighty points of preamble. Where a house names no winemaker, we have not invented one.